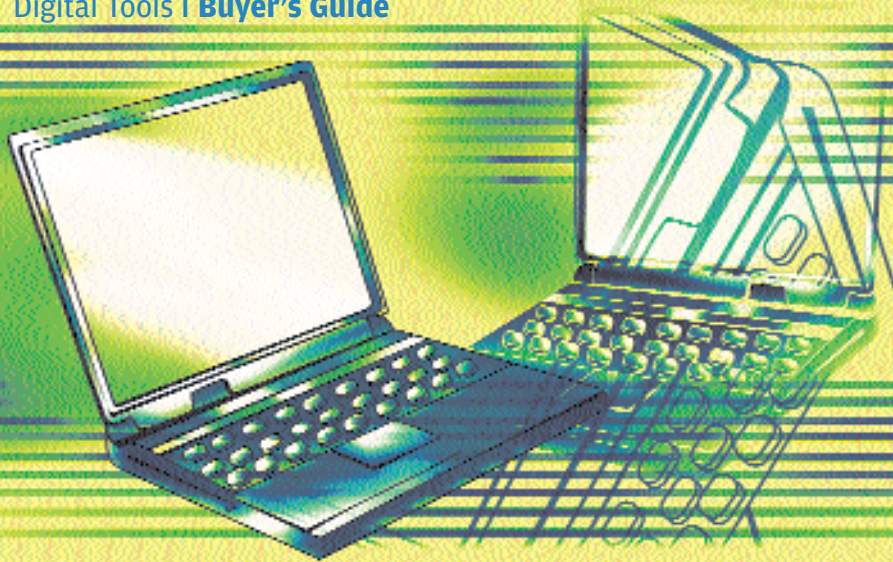




LAPTOPS

Laptops today are powerful enough to take on their desktop counterparts. They come with features such as Wi-Fi and Bluetooth, and sport fast processors—some even come with 64 bit processors. Battery life is increasing. And the price gap between desktop PCs and laptops is reducing at a quick pace.

Questions to ask the dealer

Is it upgradeable?

Though not all the components in the laptop will be upgradeable, some major components such as the CPU and RAM should be. A hot-swappable drive bay will allow you to upgrade the optical drive.

What is the battery life, and is there an extra battery pack?

Ask the dealer if the stated battery life is accurate, in his experience. An extra battery pack is a big plus.

What connectivity options are there?

Look for USB 2.0, FireWire, a memory card and a PC card reader.

Interesting Facts

The laptop computer was invented by Adam Osborne of Osborne Computers, a book company, in 1981. It was called the Osborne 1 and cost \$1,795 (Rs 18,000 in those days). It weighed 24 pounds. Epson later released the HX-20, which had a 20-character by 4-line LCD display and an inbuilt printer. In 1989, the NEC Ultralite was released. It weighed just five pounds, and this is considered by many to have been the first notebook-style laptop. The Macintosh Portable was also released that year by Apple Computer, which later evolved into the Powerbook.

Usage tips

❑ Laptops have air outlets to let out heated air. Place the laptop in such a way that there is no obstruction to this outlet.

❑ When you're using the laptop at home or office, consider using a USB mouse and keyboard—these are more ergonomic than the touchpad and the laptop keyboard.

❑ Use the power-saving features of the laptop and of the operating system to extend battery life.

❑ Viewing the laptop's small screen for prolonged periods can be very taxing on the eyes. Consider using a monitor while working in office or at home - many laptops come with a D-Sub connector to connect a monitor.



❑ To conserve battery charge, turn off the Wi-Fi when you're not using it.

The Future

nVidia has introduced MXM modules, which are replaceable graphics cards. Future laptops will use this approach to upgrade the graphics subsystem, just like in desktops. Laptops with OLED displays are not far off. This will result in an improvement in battery life—OLEDs consume much less power as compared to LCDs.

64-bit processors have already made an appearance in the laptop segment. Dual-core processors, too, are making their way into laptops, guaranteeing considerably higher performance than their single-core brethren.

Laptops capable of playing multimedia content off CD and DVD without booting into the operating system are already available.

With the price difference between laptops and desktops fast closing, you shouldn't be surprised to soon see laptops entirely replacing desktops! ■



Points To Ponder

What kind of a notebook do I need?

Home users and students should opt for moderately powerful laptops paying less attention to the portability factor. Business professionals should look for connectivity and removable drives in a moderately powerful laptop that is not only portable but also rugged. Power users such as gamers and multimedia enthusiasts should get a laptop with the fastest possible processor and a 3D graphics card, ignoring portability.

How much battery life should it offer?

If you will be using the laptop while on the move, high battery life should be given prime importance. Two hours is the minimum you should be looking at. Also, look for an additional battery pack.

Is the hard drive capacity enough for me?

Most people should be happy with 40 GB.

Do I need a processor with power saving features?

The latest processors from both Intel and AMD come with power saving features. These have better battery lives.

Do I need DVD reading capabilities?

DVD reading has become a must: DVDs have become fairly common, and many programs will soon be available only on DVD. In fact, look for a Combo drive or a DVD-Writer.

What communication options should I look for?

You should look at Wi-Fi, Bluetooth, infrared, Ethernet, and a modem.

What kind of pointing device should it have?

Choose the pointing device you're comfortable with. While a touchpad is preferred by some, some swear by the pointing stick.